

“Darling, Beauty is Pain”

Female Empowerment, Neoliberal Rationality and Class: a Postfeminist Analysis of This is Me Vatanika

Porranee Singpliam

Lecturer, Faculty of Arts, Chulalongkorn University, Bangkok, Thailand
porranee.s@chula.ac.th

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Abstract

How has postfeminist media culture traveled transnationally? What contributes to the postfeminist media's popularity in Thailand? This paper performs a content analysis of YouTube's reality show, *This is Me Vatanika*. The show features gender issues and the promotion of gender equality, enhances women's empowerment, encourages women's leadership and rhetorically calls upon its viewers to partake in the process of self-invention. I draw upon postfeminist media culture and its sensibilities and argue that this reality show inspires a new modality of femininity endemic in Thai society and that it interpolates neoliberal women in line with the logic of wealth and class, all of which impact upon female bodies. I contend that postfeminist media is increasingly evident in Thai society and the audiences' identification with and responses to the show underscore the structural gender arrangements within the society that can pose a hindrance to fully inventing oneself in the neoliberal culture.

Keywords

postfeminist media culture – reality show – femininity – neoliberal subject – classed body

1 Introduction

This is Me Vatanika (hereafter *This is Me*), the first season, begins with the elite celebrity, Vatanika, rising from her bed, her back bare and exposed, partially

covered with a white sheet. We are witness to her morning routine as she departs for work in style and heads to the Vatanika Group headquarters, then proceeds to a photoshoot. When she returns to her residence, the audience sees her stripping off her gown, her back bare again, as she daintily lifts a glass of wine from a tray served by her male butler and unwinds for the night at her posh residence. The second season of the reality show returns with a similar introduction only to begin with the celebrated English-speaking homemaker, (Poonpiriya 2018), getting the morning ready for Vatanika and serving her tea. This time, the Thai designer and entrepreneur's front body lures the audience in, with a scene of her soaking in a bathtub and, shortly thereafter, departing for her headquarters. The brief prelude ends with her emerging out of her private jet as a horde of cameramen scramble to photograph this ostentation of wealth and influence.

This reality show aired on YouTube for two seasons. *This is Me* premiered in August of 2018 and ended the last episode of season 2 in September 2019. In its first season, almost every episode gained more than one million views, while the second season garnered fewer views on YouTube with only a few episodes surpassing one million views (generally, similar shows like these earn one million views or above). The number of episodes was reduced from twelve in the first season to eight in the second season. *This is Me* depicts the extravagant and sumptuous lifestyle of a working woman regarded as a Thai socialite. *This is Me* audiences celebrate Vatanika as their "idol" and "role model." They especially consider what she represents as enviable or aspirational: her accomplishments as a professional career woman who single-handedly designs, creates and manages her own clothing line identical with her name and the way she relishes her lifestyle and conspicuous consumption. *This is Me* portrays not only a member of the female elite but also the close group of friends, family, and staff who surround her, notably her trusted matron, Saa Jaa, the chauffeur, Gob, the female employees at Vatanika headquarters, her English-speaking butler, Trent and her personal chef, Olivier Mimousin. For the most part, the reality show takes place at "Vatanika's Residence" and her luxurious office where her clothing company is located. Every so often, the show features lavish visits to a luxury resort in the Southern part of Thailand. Even more extravagantly, the show follows Vatanika on her jaunts to Europe for relaxation and to gather new ideas and draw inspiration for her clothing designs.

When *This is Me* premiered, it generated strong reactions from various sectors of society. The show was met with criticism over its imitation of the American reality show, *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* (Swenson 2008), and from online observations which pointed out that many of the show's scenes were "too staged". As the author of an article in the online

newspaper *The Standard* emphasizes, this type of reality show is always scripted (Swensen 2018), both for the dialogue and the choice of locations where the show would be filmed. Alongside the show's aim to market its clothing brand, it also highlights the issue of gender equality, women's rights, and empowerment. The underlying neologism by characters on the show is that of being a modern woman.

The show seeks to align with social issues such as addressing women's bodies and female empowerment, reflecting the 2018 campaign "Don't Tell Me How to Dress" led by the popular Thai model Cindy Sirinya, as well as the project in the following year when Vatanika partnered UN Women to raise funds in support of women and girls, specifically with a goal towards "Women's Empowerment Principles for Businesses" (Duishebaeva 2019, n.p.). Ostensibly, the show seeks to transcend mere entertainment by underlining or forwarding particular causes.

Particularly, I am drawn to investigate the following questions: What makes the show widely celebrated? Which particular elements attract audiences? And in what ways do her audiences see themselves in the show?

Clearly, the show emphasizes the gendered character that is considered distinct for a reality show (Williamson 2014; Kavka and Weber 2017) but, at the same time, it also indicates a potential weakening of the conventional gender order of present Thai society. *This is Me* deserves closer analysis for how key sensibilities, such as neoliberal subjectivity and conspicuous consumption, and global media messages intersect with the localized portrayal of gender and class (Gill 2007, 2011; Dill and Kohlman 2014; Hegde 2014; Whelehan 2014; Dosekun 2015). In the following sections, my objective is to conduct a content analysis of *This is Me* along with comments. Selected YouTube names in the comment section will remain anonymous and will be translated into English by the author. The original comments written in Thai will be put in the footnote. I attempt to argue that *This is Me*, an example of postfeminist media, appeals to the audience by entangling empowerment rhetoric embedded in the neoliberal rationality with sexist ideas. Ultimately, *This is Me's* new modality of gender formation leaves the systemic gender arrangements undervalued.

2 Theoretical Framework

Following Simidele Dosekun's adamant claim that postfeminist culture cuts across Western geopolitical space, transcends the Western locus and should be applied transnationally, Thai media culture now increasingly releases postfeminist media content on online platforms. In Dosekun's words, it urges that

postfeminist culture be reconceptualized “as transnational culture” (Dosekun 2015, 961) where women who have access to capital resources regardless of their geopolitical position can become a postfeminist subject in this culture and sensibility (Gill 2007; 2011). Emily Harmer (2015) writes that postfeminism first proposed by Rosalind Gill (2007; 2011; 2014) was conceptualized in three distinct ways: (1) postfeminism bears diverse meanings seen through postmodern scholarship; (2) postfeminism is seen as an instance that took place after the second wave of feminism; and lastly (3) postfeminism can be seen as apolitical or showing a “regressing political stance” (Harmer 2015, 34). Regarding the last point, Gill remarks that some scholars see this as a “backlash” (Gill 2007, 163) against feminism and what feminists had achieved over the waves. Postfeminism, used broadly in three ways, still cannot be uniformly agreed by scholars as to what it indubitably is (147).

However, postfeminism could be understood as the notion that highlights the empowerment of individual woman in making choice, exercising agency and consuming products and services. This is an important framework that will be used to analyze a new modality as portrayed through Vatanika. A postfeminist approach of analysis will unveil how this reality show appeals to the audience through fantastical transgression of gender and class, yet the sexist societal arrangement is left untouched.

Drawing from Dosekun’s remark that there are “both the possibility and value of reconceptualizing post-feminism *as transnational culture*,” (Dosekun 2015, 961) similarly, I argue that increasingly the Thai media, as an amalgamation of local and globalized contents, exhibits postfeminist sensibility. Postfeminist sensibility should be understood as specific attributes that include the logic of individualism, choice and the empowered female self, and the emphasis of the difference between the two sexes (women and men). Not only in those postfeminist sensibilities found in the West, other locales that celebrate heightened capitalism and the exercise of agency in non-Western societies have also seen this shift in their mediated portrayal of women. These are visible in makeover shows such as *Let Me In*, renowned celebrity blogs by Sookwan with her famous mantra “must haves,” or by the “material girl” Chompoo Arya, where key themes such as self-invention, conspicuous consumption, professionalism or contemporary motherhood for the latter figure are featured.

It must be noted that feminist thought had been embodied and absorbed by Thais in various social dimensions such as legal reform and print media, as well as the way in which gender practices and scripts have been set up locally in complementary relations between women and men (Tantiwiranond and Pandey 1987; Van Esterik 1999; Satha-anand 2004). On the surface, Thai

society seems to be doing well in terms of gender parity as stated in the statistical data from the World Economic Forum where Thailand currently ranks 73rd out of 153 countries in the Global Gender Gap Index Ranking, 2020. Additionally, the UNDP reports that the Gender Inequality Index ranks Thailand 84th in the 2018 index (HDR UNDP 2019). Ostensibly, Thai society includes women in many of its socio-economic and even political dimensions (albeit in limited numbers). It is safe to say that feminist thought exists in Thai society even though, historically, there were no unified feminist movements in distinct “waves” as such.

Postfeminism, as a celebration of women’s empowerment focusing on the individual level, is thus encouraged to be understood as neither a body of scholarship nor a historical shift, but as sensibility (Gill 2007, 148). Given the unique character in which hierarchy and class are deeply embedded in Thai society, criticism on postfeminism and its regression in the political stance among women complicates the way in which *This is Me*’s main celebrity figure, Vatanika, connects with the audience. Because the high material standard of living in elite Thai society can only be attained by some, turning towards the media becomes almost like a utopic site for the audience to relinquish their desire in terms of social mobility and, more significantly, gendered empowerment that is already rooted in class distinction.

Imelda Whelehan writes that “image makers are attuned to dominant social concerns, and the ventriloquizing of feminist themes in popular culture forestalls criticism and heightens the pleasure of textual engagement if one feels that understanding intertextual feminist/postfeminist references is the reward for a sophisticated reading of a text” (Whelehan 2014, 13). Precisely, this is the pleasure that the audience gains from watching the show. They feel empowered yet know that this empowering is an engagement with the text, the mediated message of subjective empowerment. Audiences are shown the possibilities of reshaping their lives and opportunities to acquire a similar lifestyle (Franco 2008). The central message is, if you work hard, you can enjoy life in similar circumstances. All the while, concerning issues that may include class hierarchy, neoliberal ideology and its unequal impact in the society, and structural gender arrangements within the society, become secondary.

For some, *This is Me* is indeed the representation of a modern woman in Thai popular culture made accessible through social media platforms. In the show, the rhetoric of being a modern woman and female empowerment is continuously repeated, effectively erecting a façade by providing pleasure for its audience with feminist references. As Whelehan urges us to not overlook “the possibility that postfeminist popular culture, itself a commodified,

politically empty feminism, gives the female consumer all the ‘feminism’ she requires” (Whelehan 2014, xi), it is important to re-examine how Vatanika functions as a role model that empowers the feminist drive, all the while enjoying the prerogatives she is entitled to both because of merit and embedded hierarchy. It is possible that the audience appreciates and even anticipates the reality show “alongside the reinvigoration of inequalities and the emergence of new forms and modalities of power” (Gill and Scharff 2011, 1). Significantly this is because the audience realizes how difficult it is for them to attain the same lifestyle in their lived reality, amid the entrenched hierarchized Thai society. Thus, it is important to consider how *This is Me* provides both a “source of personal empowerment” to its audience, while at the same time reproducing “social oppression” by exposing the socio-economic gap (Goodman 2014, 359).

Thus, I will perform a content analysis of this reality show. Engagement with the media on an online platform is an empowering site and at times, genuine feedback (though anonymous) can potentially put societal norms into question as Tanja Cartensen asserts about communication on social media where “Social networking sites facilitate exchanges of information, discussions, and comments. They provide spaces for users to empower each other, to establish events and protests and mobilize for political action. The design of social media enables a dense interdependence of feminist discussions” (Carstensen 2014, 489) where the already established “gender relations would be in flux” (484). YouTube is precisely the space to do this. Unlike traditional broadcasting television, *This is Me*’s new and unconventional narratives on gender, specifically, on being modern women are best portrayed through a social media platform for the new platform often is and can be produced by the users themselves. It offers “diverse representations” (Hanckel 2019, 204) in the field that the mainstream and conventional broadcasting production may frown upon. It allows for feasibility of what is being portrayed transgressing the mainstream gendered notions. In Hanckel’s words, these new digital technologies, are a site that offers “alternative ways” to imagine “sex, sexuality, and gender” (204).

Drawing from the scholarship of postfeminist sensibilities by Rosalind Gill, I will examine how *This is Me* and the characters presented in the show exhibit a novel way to perform and shape feminine subjectivities. I will also situate how Vatanika herself is the quintessential embodiment of a neoliberal subject in the deep-rooted hierarchical neoliberal Thai society where corporeal capital stands for respectability, which is imposed upon women’s bodies the most.

3 “New” Femininity

In this section, I will examine how *This is Me* portrays a new modality of femininity largely praised by its viewers. I will explore how this “new” femininity deviates from the convention of femininity deemed appropriate and respectable in Thai society. Traditionally, Thais conceptualize femininity to include gendered attributes such as being chaste, obedient and modest (Boonmongkon and Jackson 2012). Drawn from the biological deterministic discourse, imperative for the essentialist approach, this approach looks at how culture exerts pre-determined qualities on to the sexed bodies. In this case, predestined sexed bodies are the original site where the society, culture and the state exercise bio-power onto Thai female bodies. Thai women are expected to epitomize the feminine “ideals.” I aver that the gendered expectations customary in Thai culture are changing rapidly as conceptions of pluralism of genders, sexes and sexualities dominate the Thai public arena, be they calls for legal reform, activism or even academic pedagogy. The media culture is no exception, especially postfeminist media culture in Thai society where we can see individuals who overtly expand traditional gender attributions.

This is Me’s version of femininity is nothing like normative Thai femininity. The show promotes female independence “in a way befitting the confident era” (Maddox 2019, 9). Vatanika is bold, confident and uncompromising, both professionally and in her personal life. Viewers are shown many episodes where she adamantly asserts which style and pattern she likes on the models or which particularities she prefers her designs to be materialized. We are shown how the process of new womanhood is embodied in herself and her clothing line. This delicacy on the verge of assertiveness is what the audience commends as female independence, of one who speaks her mind and does not adhere to expected gendered qualities. Some comments discuss the audacious feminine qualities as follows:

I like Khun Prae (Lady Prae [Vatanika’s nickname]) because she is a woman who embodies both femininity and masculinity. She is beautiful, yet she is also manly and strong at the same time. Like, she is really beautiful but she also embodies chivalry.

At first, I was planning to only “skim” through the show because of the hype that surrounds it. I wanted to see why the show became so popular. And I was hooked! I like this show—it is not fake. I get annoyed watching other reality shows. Khun Prae’s reality show is excellent and it appeals to my inner self. It’s as if Vatanika and friends are exuding positive energy

towards me. I feel confident whenever I watch your show. It makes me want to dress up, to create a better self, to be strong. I'm glad I get to watch your show. Please continue making episodes that are unconventional like these!

This is Me's new modality of femininity challenges the traditional gendered scripts deemed apt for women in the local culture. This new type of feminine self who is daring, driven and very capable are relatable to the audiences. Vitrally important as part of the new femininity is the reiteration of sex differences between women and men.

Vatanika herself mentions in season 1 episode 4 where she was asked to be a part of the campaign #DontTellMeHowToDress where men must control themselves and their inner desires or proclivity so as not to harass women. In her words, "What is the definition of 'too revealing'? I don't know. But I know what appropriate (*kalathesa*)¹ is. And I know time and place. If we know these 3 words, the word 'too revealing' wouldn't exist" (English from original episode). In the same episode, Vatanika heads off to a photo session where her bare body is wrapped only in tight plastic connoting that women should be able to wear any type of clothes they wish and that men should honor their choice. Unlike the exhibition that took off as part of this campaign entitled "Social Power Exhibition Against Sexual Assault," *This is Me* emphasizes the way men must respect women and their bodies. As a result, this fundamental claim forsakes cultural norms that shape the discourse about the gendered bodies and effectively de-emphasizes how bodies are first and foremost constructed and reproduced through discursive knowledge where certain bodies come to mean certain things in society. Contrary to how the campaign is shown on the reality show, the exhibition evinces clothing from "all walks of life," emphasizing the contrasts to and, by extension, the gap from, the structured photoshoots of renowned celebrities, chosen as the voices that reflect this societal concern.

Discourse of sex differences further includes sexualized expressions from the female characters on the show. Gill underscores how "women's bodies as the site of femininity are closely related to the pervasive sexualization of contemporary culture" (Gill 2007, 150), which is prevalent in the show where the

¹ It is important to note that the concept of *kalathesa* means appropriateness, politeness and implies the intersection between that of time and place for any societal interactions. The term does not quite mean context dependent *per se* (Van Esterik 2000, 40). Van Esterik stresses the virtue given to corporeal appearances. In her words, "*Kalatesa* is very much concerned with surfaces, with appearances, but in Thai society these surfaces matter. Knowledge of *kalatesa* is expressed through dress, language, and manner." (39).

characters are the embodiment of sexual subjects rather than being the objects of sexualization. They can be said to represent “a modernization of femininity . . . in which sexual knowledge and practice are central” (151). These distinctive sensibilities are materialized through their embodied confidence and bodily disposition. Being able to dress the way they wish, emphatically because of their economic capital, is considered empowering and a “deeper form of exploitation than objectification” (152) for their own self credence as beautiful and capable modern women. Their choices are highlighted as a part of this new feminine modality. Most starkly, this is emphasized by how they stylize themselves on the show by wearing their own brand that overtly underlines and accentuates curves, busts and thighs. They are always portrayed as voluptuous and their bosom area is always on display. The sexualization of femininity is widely accepted by the audience. It speaks to the contemporary epoch where female bodies are to be treated with their own agency, not the mere absent presence that complies with societal regulatory practices. Specifically, one comment praises: “More than anything, Khun Prae’s bust is something else entirely, they are gorgeous!”

This is Me’s new modality of being feminine could be best explained by Gill’s remark that “Discourses of sexual difference also serve to (re-)eroticize power relations between men and women. On one level this simply means that difference is constructed as sexy. On another, discourses of natural gender difference can be used to freeze in place existing inequalities by representing them as inevitable and . . . pleasurable” (Gill 2007, 159). Sexualized feminine subjects reveal that gendered expectations and gendered scripts endemic in the local culture are being challenged. Inevitably, this new womanhood reveals the instability of the normative discourse on sexed and gendered bodies as can be deciphered through Judith Butler’s notion of regulatory ideals that:

“Sex” is an ideal construct which is forcibly materialized through time. It is not a simple fact or static condition of a body, but a process whereby regulatory norms materialize “sex” and achieve this materialization through a forcible reiteration of those norms. That this reiteration is necessary is a sign that materialization is never quite complete, that bodies never quite comply with the norms by which their materialization is impelled.

quoted in EVANS AND LEE 2002, 26

By choosing not to materialize the traditional modality of femininity, the female characters on the show challenge the gendered norm. I argue that *This is Me’s* stylization of their feminine characters poses dissent and can be said

to weaken the regulatory ideals of femininity. This new mode of femininity exposes how impermanent the normative practices are, especially without the constant replication of the normative feminine self.

It appears that the sexualized aspects, namely their corporeal adornment and their conversational style used within their group of friends, added on to the conceptualization of femininity, are the only “new” feminine modality that are portrayed in the show. In parallel with the sexualized aspects, messages that reproduce the sexual difference between women and men are shown concurrently. In season 2, episode 2, the show takes us back to how women of today should not have to possess feminine qualities deemed intrinsic for women with “wife material”. When provoked by her younger sister who says that she cannot do what most “wife material” women can do, Vatanika goes on to mock the ideal feminine gendered roles by ironically recreating the classic *The Stepford Wives*.² Vatanika shows her “attempts” to learn the domestic feminine tasks while keeping her appearances in check. And as expected, she fails at these feminine tasks.

I read this particular episode as an important part of “irony and knowingness” distinctive of postfeminist sensibility (Gill 2007, 159). By restoring the narrative from *The Stepford Wives*, the characters voluntarily manipulate “the use of retro imagery and nostalgia [as] a key device in the construction of contemporary sexism” (160). Both her friends, her family and some audience all voice their “concerns” that Vatanika might have a hard time finding a partner because of her “strong” personality and her lack of feminine qualities deemed necessary for a compulsory heterosexual relationship. Though the appearance of female independence is shared or extolled by many of Vatanika’s fans online, parts of the show still portray essential elements of the reassertion of the difference between the sexes.

Gill’s statement that “irony also functions through the very extremeness of the sexism expressed” (Gill 2007, 160) sounds a loud alarm in the discourse that constructs sex, sexuality and gender in Thai media culture today despite the new feminine modality that values women’s agency to exercise, maneuver and express their sexuality and style their bodies in ways they want to. Also, it

2 Directed by Frank Oz in 2004, *The Stepford Wives* portrays women and men in the town called Stepford where they are “programmed” into what is considered ideal masculine men (leader, breadwinner, with sexual drive) and feminine women (subservient, a homemaker, and sexually pleasing to their partners). Interestingly, the film’s lead female, Joana (played by Nicole Kidman), is characterized as an executive producer who got fired from her job and moves to Stepford only to discover the underlying reason why women are so obedient in this town, which is due to the controlling done to their gendered characters, all to wipe off their previous jobs’ traits such as judges and executives to become the *housewife* trope.

is more laudable if they also retain traditional mannerisms, especially knowing and observing the principle of seniority and *kalathesa*. While this “new” gendering of the self is commended and can be argued to potentially weaken the conventional gendered expectation, the reassertion of the essentialist discourse on sex difference remains. What this does is that it allows for the rhetoric of “empowering” women to exist alongside sexist culture that many see and feel in their lived experiences. And precisely, it is this “entanglement” of feminist and sexist ideas that draws the audiences into viewing the show because of its emphasis on empowerment even as systemic gender arrangements continue to be trivialized.

4 **Inventing Modern Woman**

I begin this section with Gill’s assertion on the relation between postfeminist culture and neoliberal ideology. Gill deduces and asks whether “neoliberalism is always already gendered, and that women are constructed as its ideal subjects?” (Gill 2007, 164) Like postfeminist culture, neoliberal logic also calls upon women as their “ideal disciplinary subject” (156). Online, Vatanika is treated as her fans’ “idol” and their “inspiration.” They aspire to invent their feminine subjectivity and enjoy the material culture the way they see women do on screen. I wish to illustrate how “postfeminist neoliberal economies” (Genz 2015, 545) interpellate feminine subjects to effectively reconsider their subjectivity, especially their autonomous agency. This very incentive to self-surveillance and self-monitoring is aspired to by many on their path to self-invention. The idiom of modern woman seen on the show calls upon what Stéphanie Genz asserts to be “affective labor” (Genz 2015, 547) whereby emotional disposition plays a key role that connects the fans and Vatanika. Because to achieve material success is arduous in a deeply hierarchical social structure such as Thailand, the spectatorship to *This is Me* ultimately acts as a source of escape and a fantastical position making it possible for women to gaze upon their favorite celebrity.

The show would not be as popular if there were less sexualization of the characters, a distinct sensibility essential to the postfeminist culture. On the one hand, *This is Me* reveals how neoliberal-aligned portrayal is a source of motivation, but on the other, it is the show’s underlying messages that “problematically individualise ‘success’ and ‘failure’ and obscure social and economic inequalities” (Allen and Mendick 2013, 89). Modern women’s sensibility is an achievement that can only be attained by some. Moreover, it is a unique attribute of class-based women. I want to make clear that the logic of neoliberalism “understood as a mode of political and economic rationality characterized by privatization, deregulation and a rolling back and withdrawal of the

state" (Gill and Scharff 2011, 5) affects Thai society differently in comparison to the Western context.³ It is tempting to consider *This is Me* entirely as postfeminist media culture, which it would be if I were to analyze *only* the episodes. The observation of the online engagement, which contributes to the show's success, prevents me from discarding the social structure endemic in Thai society.

I draw on Dosekun's (2015) assertion that postfeminist culture travels transnationally and should be thought of "neither as an epistemological perspective nor as an historical shift" (Gill 2007, 148) but that the construction of a neoliberal subject is more complex than those in the West. In short, "postfeminist neoliberal economies" (Genz 2015, 545) are distinct element of the culture of postfeminist media, but "how transnational post-feminism necessarily meeting local historicized gendered conditions" (Dosekun 2015, 970) may obstruct the audience's wishes to accomplish self-determination.

Thai women were most affected by the neoliberal capitalism adopted by the country in the late twentieth century (Phongpaichit and Baker 1995; Hewison 2005; Emmons 2019). It is precisely the way the audience sees how luxurious the neoliberal feminine subjects are portrayed on *This is Me* that draws them in to this classed and gendered "reality" which "involves the production and manipulation of affect" (Genz 2015, 547) when viewing the show. Whether or not the materiality of the modern woman may be possible for all remains uncertain given the locally entrenched hierarchy and the dominant heteropatriarchal structure. But *conceptually*, female audiences share in common the rhetoric of "feminine empowerment," but it is certain that the show "do[es] not seek an answer" (Maddox 2019, 3) whether or not their fans can be at the same level. The dramatization of individualism and empowerment per se is what gives the show's recognition.

So, the question is, to whom exactly are these messages addressed? Radha S. Hegde writes that "gendered norms and sexuality are now to be negotiated within the local contexts against the presence of this global force" (Hegde 2014, 98) to underscore the way in which the globally invested discourse of

3 Radha S. Hegde writes that due to neoliberal capitalism, it has created a shift in values and lifestyles that allows the individual to imagine the self through the act of consumption, of transformation, and especially of one's choice. Neoliberalism has made many issues in society (one outstanding polemic issue is sexism) seem idiosyncratic. This rationale also sets the foundation for postfeminist culture (Hegde 2014, 97). Seemingly, neoliberal ideology and postfeminist culture correspond to the transformation of the self, particularly that of gendered self, but it must be cautioned that when this rationale is applied in the Thai context, the uneven development and entrenched classed problem will become an immense hindrance that obstructs an individual in achieving the ideal postfeminist sensibilities as argued by Gill.

empowerment may affect and be responded to by subjects differently in diverse geopolitical areas. Having Vatanika acting as a role model for young Thai women then becomes an intriguing point of examination.

In episode 4 of season 2, Vatanika attends Harper's Bazaar's "Incredible Women Dinner" held in Bangkok; the event gathers women of different professions to share their stories and to inspire and motivate one another. The women share their experiences, mostly from their time abroad, and how they became who they are due to their past experiences. Coupled with the rhetoric of 2018's "empowering beauty" endorsed most evidently through the Miss Universe Thailand competition, it is a time when women are induced to be who they are, without fear and must realize that they are the only ones who can transform themselves for the better, to be empowered. It is no wonder that the motives such as "being oneself" and 'pleasing oneself' . . . resonate powerfully with the emphasis upon empowerment and taking control [and a] grammar of individualism underpins all these notions" (Gill 2007, 153) so much so that postfeminist elements portrayed through the show can be interpreted as depoliticized.

Arguably, Vatanika stands for "the notion that all our practices are freely chosen and [are] central to postfeminist discourses, which present women as autonomous agents no longer constrained by any inequalities or power imbalances whatsoever" (153). I wish to cast doubt on the logic of feminine empowerment, especially when the hyperreal portrayal on the show contrasts with the comments to be discussed next.

The fact that postfeminist culture is "a 'particularly rich context' for 'self-branded girls' who are encouraged to be self-reliant and empowered within consumer culture" (quoted in Genz 2015, 547) echoes loud and clear through the stylist, Art Araya and her prep talk in the fashion show in season 2 episode 4, underpinning classist society where she claims "remember women can be beautiful, powerful, modern and elegant at the same time, and women can be everything" (English from original episode). Not everyone will be able to purchase or afford the modern "femininity" that the designer's clothing brand embodies, which automatically prevents individual self-transformation in the way their "idol" can. This, however, preserves the sensibility distinct to postfeminist media in neoliberal logic. The lure is there and it encourages the subjects to "be everything," as this is the specificity of postfeminist media in Thailand that exists on screen for the spectator to gaze upon and *affectively* identify with.

The "highly condensed and schematic representation of hegemonic cultural representations" (Dosekun 2015, 963) of postfeminist media culture must be "de-centered" (963) because of the class distinction. This does not mean that

I wish to deconstruct the specific attribute of postfeminist culture in any way. Rather, I wish to highlight how the comments acknowledge the palpable component of the empowering and individualistic rhetoric. In other words, while the empowered characters on the show are shown to indulge in conspicuous consumption and the lavish lifestyle is meant as a source of inspiration for the audience, they are also enjoyed as a “postfeminist celebrity spectacle” (Hegde 2014, 97).

I end this section by referring to Hegde’s remark on the asymmetry that may evade analysis on media and gender. In particular, this refers to the case of postfeminist media culture and its audience, that the emblematic “structural oppression” (Hegde 2014, 92) is imperative for the consideration of the neoliberal feminine subject and her access to cultural capital be it taste, lifestyle, and the transformation of self as this particular comment observes:

[Vatanika] Talking about “human rights” and saying “it serves them [the models for the fashion show] right to stay being props.” What a . . . Women these days commend her as their “idol”. This shows that anyone wishes to be accepted by being assuredly assertive, especially from a woman. This is indeed a privilege entitled to prerogatives only.

To say that all the fans commend her is not entirely correct. From the comment above, it is clear that there are “neoliberal paradoxes” where the rationality of individualism and choice encourages the audience to gain empowered agency, while realizing its “precarious” limit that the attainment to female empowerment is “disproportionate” (Baer 2016, 21). Constructing the modern woman seen on screen is thus not attainable for all and this is where Baer criticizes neoliberalism logic as appearing to be empowering while its “oppressive nature” is successfully concealed (2016, 17). The celebration of female empowerment is thus contingent upon class.

5 Corporeal Capital, Sexed Body, and Class

Alluring femininity is an integral part of postfeminist sensibility. Following Gill’s claim that “possession of a ‘sexy body’ is presented as women’s key (if not sole) source of identity,” (Gill 2007, 149) more than anything, the women in the show exhibit the sensuality and sultriness through their stylization of the body and their bodily disposition. Vatanika is shown to be fully comfortable with her

body regardless of how “revealing” it may appear. As Gill suggests, the “bodily property” is described as a modality of femininity, meaning that femininity should not be considered as “structural or psychological” (149). Vatanika brings her body into the central focus and embodies distinct feminine attributes and gait. This is considered something admirable because, first and foremost, Vatanika exercises her power to express her “self” through her body, undisturbed by cultural inscriptions that coerce women to be cautious about their bodies. In other words, Vatanika’s body is represented as an empowered site where she exercises her power to continuously and voluntarily transform albeit under “constant monitoring, surveillance, discipline and remodelling” (149).

“Darling, beauty is pain,” utters Vatanika. Throughout the two seasons, there is not one part where we are shown the main character’s face un-made up (except in the pilot episode where she went in camouflage to inspect the local market that sells counterfeits from her clothing brand). In season 1 episode 7, Vatanika and her friends depart for Khaoyai, a vacation town in the Northeast, to join the “King Battle: Ultimate Battles Race,” and the show portrays a conversation between Vatanika and her friend, Joy, about her hairdo. We are told that Vatanika got her hair done the night before the race, slept through it, and even though she felt nervous about the race, she claims “If I don’t win, my hair wins anyway” (English from original episode). Though this brief conversation may seem trivial, it reveals how the characters on the show are always preoccupied with self-surveillance and self-monitoring in order to perfect their bodily appearances, quite literally from head to toe. Jennifer L. Graves and Samantha Kwan (2012) writes that these strict bodily scripts would go on to homogenize the feminine bodies. They assert that bodily scripts are inherent components and indivisible from gendered scripts which reiterate the sex differences between those of masculine men and feminine women.

Women’s bodies are both being commended and always under scrutiny. The laudable aspect of Vatanika’s body is how it is so “extravagant” in the sense that it embodies corporeal capital that is connotative of her class. Feminine bodies such as Vatanika’s deviate from the traditional gendered embodiment—to be chaste, for instance (Laphimon 2012). Her body is her own property, to manipulate and to transform to the best version. This freedom from the cultural inscription especially outside of the culture’s grip (Bordo 2003, 16) is what lures the audiences into a culture of postfeminist attributes.

Vatanika’s body is not just any body but one that embodies respectability (Blackman 2008; Ganetz 2011). Vatanika’s taste and lifestyle is one evident proof that allows a classed body to achieve postfeminist sensibility. As mentioned in the previous section, to be able to attain the epitome of feminine

bodily disposition is not about being beautiful but being “extravagantly” beautiful where splurged consumption and wealth are highlighted.

Respectability comes with corporeal capital. This notion is “in parallel to Bourdieu’s analysis of the class-based acquisition of cultural capital” (Whelehan 2014, 8) where economic capital is not the only the means to identify a person’s class in the society, but also symbolic elements such as taste, bodily gait, and communicative style that designate one into a class of hierarchical position. To be able to embody respectability akin to what is shown in the postfeminist media culture, women must be from a certain class, express heightened sexuality that defines their feminine subjectivity and maintain the sex differences between those of men and women. It appears that Vatanika embodies the elements necessary to showcase the new feminine self deemed respectable in the neoliberal society where the conventional and modern feminine attributes do not cancel out one another.

Vatanika, being the trend setter for the fashion industry and many women who aspire to be like her, indulges in the concept of “lifestyle” so much so that the feminine body cannot be conceptualized *sans* pleasure, continuous bodily transformation and sexualization of the bodily comportment. Postfeminist insights maintain that the normative body within this culture is in parallel with the (neo-) capitalist society which Pierre Bourdieu argues is the focal point of a bourgeois class that “demands a social world which judges people by their capacity for consumption, their ‘standard of living’, their life-style, as much as by their capacity for production” (Whelehan 2014, 8). Vatanika who embodies class and a sexualized feminine figure represents Skeggs’ (1997) assertion that “the body is the most indisputable materialization of class tastes” (quoted in Blackman 2008, 63).

In addition, the display of flesh is perceived by the audiences as representing power, particularly female power to stylize their bodies. Bodies that appear on the show are all considered idealistic where the feminine physique is accentuated, their bust revealed and their hips emphasized and proportionate. The representation of female bodies on *This is Me* denotes normalization, women’s “second nature” (Orbach 2016, 3), while at the same time underpinning the agency to transform their bodies. It can be interpreted that having meticulous feminine bodily proportions is anticipated from this type of celebrity reality show.

Postfeminist media culture perceives the female body as their own corporeal property, for them to manipulate and transform for their own gain. The result from this body transformation reproduces qualities that are expected from the Butlerian “heterosexual matrix” (Sanders 2017, 49). Feminization of the body in the postfeminist media is considered normative and has the potential to

create homogeneous images on the media platform. In other words, the gendered body can maintain the culture's grip similar to Bordo's argument that goes "against proponents of the absolute heterogeneity of culture, [that] there are dominant, strongly 'normalizing' (racial and gendered) forms to contend with" (Bordo 2003, 29). The popularity of the show indicates that the fans and the audience of the show strongly identify with the feminine embodiment.

6 Conclusion

Postfeminist media culture has indeed "gone global" (Dosekun 2015, 973). *This is Me* is just one of the many reality shows produced by Thai women on a media platform that resist the traditional modality of gender performativity in contemporary society. The prominence of this type of media, especially the sensibilities portrayed in it, can potentially pose a threat to the traditionally assumed embodied feminine selves.

I contend, however, that the new modality of being feminine is not for everyone. The fact that neoliberalism affects subjects differently locally prohibits some women from attaining the respectable form of being feminine, which includes class-based consumption and appearance. It is highlighted that in the era of late capitalism and the neoliberal induced policy, "the shift from a culture of production to one of consumption, as represented by celebrity," reflects the audience's desire to catch up and embody neoliberal subjectivity (Williamson 2014, 312). The audiences who gaze upon the women on the show thus "affectively" identify with the characters, reiterating how material necessities are vital to create the neoliberal subject, and to have full autonomy in attaining the sensibilities required by the postfeminist culture, one must possess both economic and corporeal capital. The hindrances to fully realizing postfeminist sensibility, I argue, is pervasive in Thailand where class hierarchy is deeply embedded and social connections rather than merit enable individuals to "speak" for Thai women. In other words, neoliberal subjectivity, a significant component for the discursive construct of a modern woman in the postfeminist culture, is one obstacle that not only an individual but also the structures of the society as a whole must contend with.

This is why shows like these are increasingly popular in Thai society even though only a few academic works are associated with postfeminist sensibilities and how this distinct media culture communicates in different geopolitical areas. I maintain that postfeminist sensibilities are a critical theoretical tool useful for analyzing and recognizing *This is Me's* currency as it heightens the gap between Vatanika and the fans. *This is Me* provides a channel for the

audience to reflect upon their gender identification, especially the emphasis on the sexualized female subject and its intersection with society.

This is Me enhances the notion that “everything is about me” or is about how I should work for myself, for my own gain and my wealth (Genz 2015; Iqani 2018). This empowering feminist perspective becomes, what I fear, rhetorical for some audience. Thus, I wish to encourage further research to delve more closely into the lived experiences of fans of this type of media culture. Innovative research can be imagined and qualitative analysis through interviews with fans from various economic, cultural or social backgrounds is needed to gain deeper insight into how the discourses of empowerment and women’s agency are perceived by the fans of the show. I believe that research conducted in this way will open a discussion on the structural issue that is implicit in the way *This is Me* appears to the audience, which is the reproduction of sexualized subjectivity and heterosexual relations.

I end this paper with points raised by Rosalind Gill and Christina Scharff regarding the lack of conversation about sexist society when they write, “No one uses the word sexism anymore’ . . . It has an old-fashioned, almost quaint ring about it. Instead, the *mots de jour* are terms like ‘choice’ and ‘empowerment’. . .” (2011, 1) as it is overtly discussed in the mediated messages through this type of reality show. This type of discourse portrayed in the media has the potential to both narrate autonomy and encourage agency amongst women, yet it can potentially engender a façade to cover up a structural component as rigid such as that of heteropatriarchal society, even without uttering a word on sexism. Postfeminist media culture thus contributes to self invention in line with neoliberal society, yet as Bordo asserts, we must “highlight . . . a discourse that encourages us to ‘imagine the possibilities’ and close our eyes to limits and consequences” (Bordo 2003, 39). In other words, it is imperative to accentuate how sensibilities may de-emphasize political issues such that of class, hierarchy and illusive empowerment.

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